The Names We Kept

A Historical Novel

CHAPTER ONE

The first knock came just after the kettle began to complain.

It was measured, neither timid nor impatient: three taps, a pause, then two more. Helena had heard enough knocks in Warsaw to know that some were asking and some were only informing the door that it had become irrelevant. She laid her needle across the coat in her lap and listened.

At the table, Marysia stopped counting beans.

The kettle shivered on the little iron stove. Outside the window, a cart creaked over the frozen ruts in the street, and somewhere below them a radio was cut off in the middle of a man's sentence. The silence afterward seemed to climb the stairwell.

"Is it the landlord?" Marysia whispered.

"The landlord knocks once." Helena lifted the coat from her knees. "And he waits for me to answer."

The girl's eyes moved to the window. They were a pale, uncertain blue, the colour of winter water under cloud. Helena had spent years teaching herself not to see another pair of eyes behind them. She reached for the kettle instead.

"Tea first," she said. "Then we can decide what sort of visitors we have."

It was not tea, exactly. The leaves had been steeped twice already, then dried on a saucer and used once more, until the cup held more warmth than flavour. Marysia drank it without complaint. She had learned the arithmetic of hunger as carefully as she learned her sums: one slice now, the smaller piece later, never ask whether there would be more.

Helena set a heel of bread between them. She had cut it thin enough to see the grain of the table through it. Marysia broke it in half and pushed the larger portion back.

"You need it," Helena said.

"I have school." Marysia gave the bread a thoughtful look. "I can be hungry there."

"No one should have to practise that. Eat."

The child obeyed, but slowly, making each mouthful last. The lessons she attended were held in the back room of a dressmaker's shop, where a woman who had once taught in a proper school continued to teach arithmetic, Polish history, and whatever else could be fitted between the hours when the street was quiet. Marysia liked sums best. They had rules, and rules, she said, were easier to remember than people.

On school mornings, Helena walked with her as far as the corner, then watched from the bakery doorway until the girl had crossed to the shop where the lessons were held. The route was short enough to memorize and long enough to contain a dozen ways to go wrong. There was the checkpoint near the tram stop, where a soldier sometimes asked children their names; the alley behind

the pharmacy, which was safe only when the market carts were there; the open ground where a building had been pulled apart and no one had yet decided what to build in its place. Marysia knew not to run, not to stare at uniforms, and not to answer questions that were not asked directly of her. She knew to forget a face as soon as she had seen it.

Helena hated that she had taught her these things. She hated more that Marysia had learned them well. The child still found time to notice small beauties: a red leaf caught in a gutter, a cat asleep on a coal sack, a patch of sun on the wall that returned for five minutes each afternoon. Helena tried to keep those observations alive in her. A childhood could be made smaller by fear, but it should not be made entirely of fear.

"How many beans?" Helena asked.

"Eleven whole ones. Three broken."

"And how many do we need?"

"More than eleven."

"That's not arithmetic."

"It's the answer I have."

Helena smiled despite herself. The smile was brief, but Marysia caught it and smiled back, pleased as if she had been given an extra slice of bread.

Helena took the cup from the stove and poured. Her fingers had cracked at the knuckles from cold water and lye soap. The needle had left a small red point on her thumb. She pressed it against the seam of her skirt until the blood stopped.

The second knock sounded from the landing.

Marysia lowered her bread. Helena set the kettle down without pouring.

A door opened below them. A man's voice asked a question in German. Someone answered in Polish, too faintly to make out. Then came the scuff of boots on the stairs, one flight, then another. Helena glanced at the cupboard beside the stove. Behind the stack of folded linen, under a loose board, lay the papers she had kept hidden since Marysia was born: a baptismal certificate, a civil slip bearing Helena's name and no father's, and one square of paper she had never been able to burn.

She had hidden them so long that hiding had become a habit. She did not need to look at the cupboard to know where the board sat. The square of paper among the documents was not an official record. It was a midwife's receipt, written in a neat hand on the back of a pharmacy bill, with the date of Marysia's birth and the name Helena had never allowed onto a civil form: Friedrich von Brandt. The midwife had offered to burn it. Helena had said no, then spent the next nine years wishing she had.

At the registry office, when the clerk asked for the father's name, she had stood with Marysia wrapped in a blanket against her chest and felt the answer rise to her tongue. She could have said Friedrich's name. It would have made the child legitimate in one country and endangered in another. She could have invented a dead Polish man, but even a dead man left a trail of parents, neighbours, and graves. In the end, she had said nothing. The clerk had drawn a line through the space and moved on to the next form.

That blank had seemed safer than a lie that could be checked. It had seemed like a wall.

"Mamo?"

"Go to the bedroom."

"I can—"

"Now, Marysia. Take your book."

Marysia looked as if she might argue, then saw something in her mother's face and went. The thin door clicked shut behind her. Helena crossed the room, smoothed the coat where it had bunched across her lap, and placed the needle in the pincushion. When the men reached her floor, she was standing with both hands free.

The first man wore a field-grey uniform and a leather belt polished pale at the buckle. A second uniformed man stood behind him, one hand resting near the strap of his pistol. Between them was a civilian in a black overcoat, his hat tucked under his arm, a folder held against his chest. He had the careful, dry look of someone who believed a form could not be cruel because it had no hands.

"Frau Wojtera?" he asked.

"Miss Wojtera."

His eyes moved over her face, measuring the correction. "Helena Wojtera, of this address?"

"Who wants to know?"

The civilian showed a paper. He held it so that she could see the stamp and the typed lines without taking

it from him. Her name was there, then the name of the street, then the number of the building. Beneath that, in a different hand, was the date of Marysia's birth.

Helena did not let her gaze linger.

"The municipal office has requested the child for a review of her registration," he said. "She is to accompany us for a short examination."

"What examination?"

"Her family status."

"She is nine years old. Her papers are in order."

"That is what we are here to establish."

The two soldiers had not moved. The one in front watched Helena. The other looked past her into the flat, taking in the table, the stove, the single narrow bed visible beyond the half-open door. The civilian's folder had a leather tie around it. A line of red pencil marked the page he had opened.

"Show me the full order," Helena said.

"This is the order."

"This is a notice. It has no signature from the district office."

His mouth tightened. "You have learned to read German."

"I learned it before your office became interested in my child."

For a moment, the civilian's expression sharpened. Then he restored the mildness, as if he had put on a

glove. "There are questions about her ancestry. The child is to be taken to a place where she can be examined properly. You may come with her if your identification is valid."

"What questions?"

"A report was made."

"By whom?"

"That is not relevant."

"It is relevant to me."

The soldier behind the clerk shifted his weight. Helena heard the leather of his glove creak. She kept her hands at her sides.

The civilian glanced toward the bedroom. "We need to see the girl."

"You have not explained what you intend to do with her."

"No one intends to do anything with her. It is a routine classification. There are offices that deal with children whose records are incomplete. If her background is what the report claims, it would be better for her to be placed with a German family than left to grow up in a situation that is not suitable." He spoke gently, as if he were offering to carry a parcel upstairs. "She will be fed and educated."

Helena had heard the words in other mouths. In the queue outside the parish office, women passed stories from the east: families pushed from their houses, children lined up beneath a stranger's gaze, a choice

made about them by a person with a pencil. Some stories grew larger each time they were told. The details changed; the fear did not. One woman had said her nephew was taken for a medical examination and returned with a new name. Another had heard of a village where mothers were told their children would be sent to school, then given no address where a letter could find them. Helena had not known which parts were true. She knew that the authorities could remove a child first and explain the decision later.

She had learned to avoid asking questions in those queues. Questions made people remember that they had spoken. She had learned to listen for the words that meant a door was about to close: placement, examination, transport. The civilian had used all three without once saying where Marysia would sleep that night.

The girl was nine. She still slept with one hand curled under her cheek, and still asked Helena to check beneath the bed when the wind made the boards creak. There were days when she forgot to be afraid of the street. Helena had wanted to keep those days for her.

Helena felt the room grow smaller around the words.

"She is not a parcel."

"Then you should be grateful someone is willing to make sure she is cared for."

"I care for her."

"You are Polish."

The sentence had the flatness of an entry in a ledger. Helena looked past him at the two soldiers. The one by the door had lowered his eyes. The other still watched the room.

"You may take my papers to the office," she said. "You may write down that I refused. You will not take her out of this house."

The civilian closed the folder. "That is not your decision."

The bedroom door opened behind her.

Marysia stood on the threshold with her schoolbook held against her chest. Helena had asked her to stay inside; the girl had stayed long enough to hear the word German family. Her braid had come loose, and a strand of pale hair clung to her cheek.

"Mamo?"

Helena moved between the men and her daughter. "Go back."

The civilian looked at Marysia, then at the note on his page. He took a step toward her. "Maria Wojtera?"

"She is Marysia," Helena said.

"The child must come with us."

The first soldier reached for Marysia's arm.

Helena struck his hand away. She did not think. She moved on the same instinct that had once made her snatch a kettle from a falling shelf, before the water could scald a child. The soldier caught her wrist and twisted it behind her. Pain flared from her thumb to her

elbow. Marysia screamed. The second soldier seized the girl's coat and pulled her over the threshold.

"No!"

The sound came out of Helena as something older than fear. She drove her shoulder into the first man's chest. He stumbled into the doorframe, swore, and released her. Marysia slid on the bare floorboards. Helena caught the child around the waist and felt the thin bones beneath the wool.

"Hold on to me," she said. "Do not let go."

The soldier dragged them both toward the hall. The civilian had stepped back, his folder held to his chest. On the landing, a door opened. A neighbour's face appeared for half a second, then disappeared again. No one came out. No one could afford to come out.

A command cut through the stairwell.

"Halt."

The word was in German. It was spoken without shouting, which made the men obey faster.

The second soldier let go of Marysia. The first released Helena's wrist and turned toward the top of the stairs. A man had come up from the street, followed by a younger officer in a dark greatcoat. He wore the field-grey uniform of the Wehrmacht, his cap tucked beneath one arm. A silver oak-leaf insignia marked his shoulder. He was tall, though less than Helena remembered; or perhaps she had been smaller then.

He looked first at the soldiers, then at the civilian, then at Helena.

For one suspended instant, she saw him in a different room: a sunlit hall in Berlin, his gloves in his hand, rain at the windows, his mouth forming her name before he left. The memory came from the last afternoon they had been together, ten years earlier. She had stood on the platform with a case at her feet and a ticket to Warsaw in her glove. Friedrich had arrived late, his hair damp from the rain, and she had believed he would tell her he was coming with her.

They had been engaged for six months. Their families had met once, stiffly, over a dinner that neither family had enjoyed. His father had spoken of duty and the name Brandt; her aunt had spoken of Poland as if it were a country one could fold and put away. Friedrich had been the bridge between them, or so Helena had thought. He spoke Polish badly but earnestly. He remembered how she took her coffee. He had promised they would find a flat near the river, and that she would never have to apologize for being herself in his house.

Then Germany changed around them. The flags went up; people who had been neighbours learned new ways to measure one another. His father asked him to stay. His mother said the family could not endure another scandal. Friedrich told Helena he needed a little time to settle things, to protect his position, to make a life in which they could still be together. He never said the word choice. He only asked her to wait.

She had taken the ring from her hand and placed it in his palm. He closed his fingers around it, but did not close them around hers. The train had begun to move before he asked her to stay. She had stood by the

window until the platform slid away, watching him become one more dark figure in the rain.

She had never told him about the child. At first she had meant to write. Then the letters she drafted seemed like invitations to a man who had already chosen what he could bear to lose. By the time she had decided, the silence had become its own kind of answer. The memory passed so quickly that it seemed like a trick of the cold.

"Helena," he said.

She drew Marysia behind her. "Major von Brandt."

The younger officer glanced at him, startled by the familiarity. The civilian did not. He had turned the folder upright, and now the red mark lay covered by his fingers.

Friedrich's face had changed in ten years. There were lines at the corners of his eyes, and a fine scar cut through one eyebrow. His hair, once the colour of dark straw, had gone almost brown under the cap. The mouth was still the same: grave when he meant to be kind, cold when he meant to survive.

"What is the meaning of this?" he asked the civilian.

"An administrative review, Major. A child whose ancestry is in question. The mother is obstructing the order."

"The order authorizes an interview," Friedrich said, holding out his hand. "Not a transfer."

The civilian hesitated. "The instruction includes transport to the assessment office."

"It does not include force."

"The mother became violent."

"After your men took hold of her daughter."

One of the Feldgendarmes began to speak. Friedrich looked at him. The man closed his mouth.

The major took the paper and read it. Helena watched his eyes travel down the page. She knew the face he made when he found a discrepancy: a slight stillness around the jaw, his attention narrowing until every other thing in the room fell away. She had loved that concentration once. She had mistaken it for certainty.

"This is a notice from a local office," he said. "Where is the signed transfer order?"

"The original is being held at the district office."

"Then you do not have authority to remove the child."

"I do."

"You have an instruction to verify a report. The wording is clear. It says examination. It says nothing about custody."

The clerk reached for the paper. Friedrich did not hand it back. "The child remains here until the issuing office provides the original and the district command confirms it."

"The Army has no jurisdiction over family classification."

"The Army has jurisdiction over its own patrols. These men are Feldgendarmes. They will not assist you in removing a civilian child without a complete order."

The civilian's eyes moved to the soldiers. The one who had grabbed Marysia looked at Friedrich and then away. He knew the rank on the major's shoulder, and knew what it meant if he disobeyed in front of witnesses.

"You are delaying an official procedure," the civilian said.

"I am preventing an unauthorized one."

A pause settled over the landing. From the street came the low growl of a truck changing gears. Somewhere behind a closed door a child began to cry, quickly hushed.

The civilian closed the folder again. "I will report this."

"Please do. Include my name."

The sentence had no heat in it. That made it sound less like a threat than a fact. The civilian studied him, then studied Helena. At last he placed the folder beneath his arm.

"The mother and child will report to the district office tomorrow at nine. If they fail to appear, the order will be carried out."

Friedrich looked at the notice. "You will provide them with a written appointment."

"You have no right—"

"Then you should have no difficulty explaining why you refused."

The clerk's jaw worked once. He took a small pad from his pocket and wrote. The pencil scratched over the paper. He gave Helena a narrow slip bearing the office address and the time.

Friedrich passed the notice to his younger officer, who folded it and placed it in a document case. "Record that the child remains with her mother pending confirmation."

The soldier nodded.

"And make an entry that you were ordered to leave her here."

"Jawohl, Herr Major."

The civilian turned to Helena. "You have until nine."

"I heard him."

The men went down the stairs. Their boots struck each step with the same measured sound as the knock. The younger officer stayed behind long enough to take down Helena's address. Friedrich watched him write it. Then the two men descended after the others, leaving the smell of wet wool and tobacco in the hall.

No one spoke until the outer door shut.

Marysia clung to the back of Helena's skirt. The child's fingers were clenched in the cloth, small and cold. Helena put one arm around her shoulders. She could feel her own pulse beating against the girl's temple.

Friedrich stood three steps below them. The stairwell was narrow enough that no one could pretend not to be there.

"Are you hurt?" he asked.

"No."

His eyes dropped to the red mark around her wrist.

"It is nothing."

"I did not know you were in Warsaw."

"I did not know you were alive."

She almost laughed. The sound would have been too close to a sob, so she kept it inside. "You had ten years to find out."

"I wrote to the address you gave me."

"And when the letters came back?"

"I thought you had gone somewhere else."

"I had."

He looked past her to Marysia. The child had stopped trembling but was still holding Helena's skirt. Her eyes were fixed on his uniform. She had never seen him before, not in life. The photograph Helena had once carried was long gone; at least she had believed it was gone.

"How old is she?" he asked.

"Nine."

Friedrich's face did not alter, but the hand at his side closed once. Helena saw it. She had spent years learning how not to see what his body gave away.

"Does she have a father?" he asked.

"No."

"Helena—"

"You asked. I answered."

"I did not mean—"

"You did."

Marysia tugged at her sleeve. "Mamo, who is he?"

"An officer."

"No," Friedrich said quietly. "I am an old friend of your mother's."

Helena looked at him. "You are not."

The words struck harder than she intended. His eyes did not leave hers. For a moment, she saw the young man who had once promised that the world could not make him choose between his name and her hand. Then the memory folded away, and in its place stood a German major in a Warsaw stairwell, with soldiers waiting below and a child between them.

"You must bring the papers tomorrow," he said. "Anything that shows her place of birth and your legal status. Do not bring anything else."

"Why? So your office can copy them?"

"So I can prove the notice is defective."

"And if it isn't?"

He did not answer at once. That was answer enough.

"The order named her date of birth," he said. "It also carried a note that her father was believed to be German. The file is not a mistake. Someone has given them information."

Helena felt Marysia's head lift against her side.

"Who?"

"I don't know."

"You were quick to know the wording."

"I read it."

"You read it as if you knew what to look for."

"I looked for the part that gave them the right to take her. It wasn't there."

She glanced toward the floor below. The Feldgendarmes had reached the street. Their voices came through the open front door, briefly, then faded. Friedrich had stopped the immediate danger, but he had also written their address into a German file. By tomorrow the office would know where they lived, how old Marysia was, and which major had taken an interest in them.

"You have put us in your records," she said.

"I had to. Otherwise they could have taken her and called it a mistake."

"And now they can come back with a better order."

"Yes."

"You expect me to thank you?"

"No."

He said it without offence. Perhaps that was the only decent thing left between them: neither of them could pretend she owed him gratitude.

"I can buy time," he continued. "Not safety. If the report came from the office I think it did, the appointment tomorrow is only the beginning."

"Then do not come near her again."

"I don't have that choice."

"You have always had choices. You simply disliked the ones that cost you something."

His face tightened. The younger officer called from below, "Herr Major." Friedrich turned his head, then looked back at Helena.

"I will be at the district office at nine."

"We won't be."

"If you don't go, they'll return with the original order."

"If I do go, I hand them my daughter."

"If you go with the papers, you make it harder for them to take her."

"You mean you make it harder."

"Yes."

The answer was so plain that it unsettled her more than a defence would have. The boy she had loved used to speak as if good intentions could turn a promise into a wall. The man before her had learned to name the limits of his power. Whether he had learned to regret how he used it was another matter.

"You are asking me to trust you," she said.

"No. I am asking you to decide whether the danger is worse with me or without me."

"You have no right to ask me anything."

"You're right."

He picked up his cap. His gaze returned to Marysia. The girl leaned against Helena, watching him with an expression too serious for her age.

"I'm sorry," he said to the child.

Marysia looked up at her mother before she answered. "For what?"

Friedrich seemed to search for a word that did not excuse the uniform. He found none. "For frightening you."

"You didn't frighten me," Marysia said. "The other man did."

His mouth shifted, almost a smile, but the smile did not arrive. "Then I am sorry for not arriving sooner."

"You were busy," Helena said.

He accepted that, too. He went down the stairs, the younger officer falling in behind him. At the bottom, he

paused to speak to the men outside. Helena heard the clipped cadence of German, then the street door shut.

Marysia remained still until the sound of the vehicle had moved away.

"He knows you," she said.

"We met a long time ago."

"Was he your friend?"

Helena bent to pick up the coat from the floor. The sleeve had been dragged through dust. "I thought he was."

"Is he the reason the men came?"

"No."

It was too quick. Marysia caught the lie, or the fear behind it. She had become good at hearing what adults left out. Helena reached for the needle and found that her hand was shaking so badly she could not thread it.

"We have to go somewhere else," Marysia said.

"Not yet."

"They know where we live."

"They knew before they knocked."

"Then we should go."

"Where?"

The girl had no answer. Neither did Helena. Every room in Warsaw seemed to belong to someone who had already been questioned, searched, or made to disappear. Their few belongings could be packed in the

time it took the kettle to cool, but a person could not take a hiding place with her merely by wanting it.

Helena shut the door and slid the bolt into place. She checked the window latch, then the back stair, then the cupboard. The loose board was where it had always been. The papers lay beneath the linen, wrapped in oilcloth. The baptismal certificate was damp at one corner. The civil slip still carried her own name and the blank space where a father's name should have been.

The square of paper she had never burned was gone.

For a moment, she could not understand what she was seeing. She lifted the linen, moved the board, checked the corner of the cupboard. She searched the folded clothes, though she knew she had not moved them. The paper had been there the night before. She had taken it from its envelope, read the faded lines, then put it back. She remembered the slight tear near the top, the ink blotted by a thumbprint. She remembered returning the board to its place.

Now there was an empty patch in the dust.

"What is it?" Marysia asked from the table.

Helena closed the cupboard. "Nothing."

The answer sounded thin in the cold room. She turned to the girl, whose braid had come completely loose. A faint red mark circled her wrist where the soldier had grabbed her. Helena crossed the space between them and touched it with the gentlest part of her thumb.

"Does it hurt?"

"Only when I look at it."

"Then don't look."

Marysia studied her mother's face. "Will he come tomorrow?"

"I don't know."

"Will you go to the office?"

Helena looked at the empty cupboard, at the hidden papers, at the door that had failed to keep the world outside. She saw again the major's hand closing at the word nine. She had spent ten years believing that silence could be made permanent if she guarded it carefully enough. Now someone had found the seam.

"We will decide in the morning," she said.

Marysia nodded, accepting the delay because the alternative was fear without a name. Helena picked up the coat, threaded the needle, and returned to the work. The stitch went crooked. She pulled it out and tried again.

Outside, a truck rattled over the stones and stopped somewhere nearby. Men called to one another in German. The kettle had gone cold. On the table, the officer's appointment slip lay beside the bread, its stamped letters crisp and dark.

Helena set a saucer over it, as if a small white circle could keep the paper from being seen.

Then, while her daughter watched, she began to sew the torn lining shut.